

Hampton Court Palace - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Palace a King Took for Himself

Here's how to get a palace for free, if you're Henry the Eighth. This gorgeous red-brick palace was built starting in 1515 by Cardinal Wolsey, the king's most powerful minister — so grand that people whispered it was finer than anything the king owned. Bad move. When Wolsey failed to get Henry the divorce he wanted from his first wife, Wolsey fell from power, and Henry simply took Hampton Court for himself in 1529. Henry made it his pleasure palace: tennis courts, bowling alleys, hunting grounds, and feasting halls. He brought five of his six wives here. Remember the wives with this rhyme: divorced, beheaded, died; divorced, beheaded, survived. As you walk in through the gatehouse, look up for the astronomical clock from 1540. It shows the hour, the month, the phases of the moon — and the time of high tide at London Bridge, because guests arrived by royal barge on the Thames and needed to catch the tide home. Notice one odd thing about the clock: the sun goes around the Earth, because when it was built, everyone still believed Earth was the center of the universe. The clock is wrong about the whole cosmos, and it's still beautiful.

The Six Wives Who Lived Here

You already know the rhyme: divorced, beheaded, died; divorced, beheaded, survived. But some of those wives are not just names here. They lived, married, gave birth, and even died inside these very walls, so as you walk around, imagine them here with you.

Wife number three was Jane Seymour, and hers is the saddest and the most important story. Henry had waited his whole life for a healthy son to be his heir, and in October of 1537, right here at Hampton Court, Jane gave him one, a baby prince named Edward. There were bonfires and church bells across the whole country. And then, just twelve days later, still in this palace, Jane became terribly ill and died. Henry was heartbroken. Out of all six wives, Jane is the only one he chose to be buried next to when his own turn came. She gave him the thing he wanted most, and it cost her everything.

Wife number five was Katherine Howard, only a teenager, and her terrible day in the long gallery you may have heard about already. Wife number six was Catherine Parr, and she has a happier link to this place, because Henry actually married her here at Hampton Court in the summer of 1543, in a small private chapel room. She was clever, kind to Henry's three children, and she was the one who survived him.

Here is a detail to hunt for. Look above one of the gateways for two letters twisted together, an H and an A. They stand for Henry and Anne, meaning Anne Boleyn, wife number two, the one who was beheaded. When she fell from favour, workmen were sent rushing around the palace to chip out every H and A and replace them with H and J for Jane Seymour, because a king did not want reminders of a disgraced wife. But they worked fast, and they missed a few. So somewhere above your head, carved in stone, Anne Boleyn is still holding hands with Henry, five hundred years later, only because a busy stonemason didn't look up. See if you can be the one who spots her.

Arrive by River, and Look Up

Here's a game to play in your head. Forget the car park and the ticket gate. To arrive at Hampton Court the proper Tudor way, you came by boat. The Thames was the great highway of Henry's England, faster and cleaner than the muddy, robber-filled roads, and important guests glided up to the palace in painted royal barges rowed by teams of oarsmen. That is the real reason the astronomical clock over the gateway shows the time of high tide at London Bridge. It wasn't decoration. If you got the tide wrong, your barge could be stuck for hours, so people genuinely checked that clock the way you'd check a train time.

Now look at the walls as you pass through the courtyards, and hunt for round faces made of terracotta, which is baked orange clay. Those are Roman emperors, made by an Italian artist for Cardinal Wolsey more than five hundred years ago. Wolsey was showing off, saying to every visitor, I am modern, I am rich, I know the newest art from Italy. It was the Tudor equivalent of covering your house in the coolest, most expensive thing money could buy. Look too for Wolsey's own badge on the stonework, and enjoy the fact that the man who built all this bragging never got to enjoy it, because the king took it away from him.

Then, the best look-up of the whole day. Step into the Chapel Royal and lift your eyes to the ceiling. It is a deep, glowing blue, the colour of a night sky, studded and ribbed with gold, with golden angels blowing trumpets hanging down. It was made of wood and painted for Henry nearly five hundred years ago, and unlike most of the palace it has barely changed. Kings and queens knelt under that exact ceiling. And in the Great Hall next door, look up again at the enormous wooden roof, held together with no nails, just gigantic beams of oak jigsawed together by carpenters who never saw a machine. Two ceilings, one blue and gold, one all timber, both hundreds of years old, both still up there waiting for you to notice them.

The Tudor Kitchens: Feeding 600 People Twice a Day

Follow your nose to the Tudor kitchens — the biggest kitchens of their time in England, fifty-five rooms run by two hundred staff. Their job: feed the six hundred people of Henry's court, twice a day, every day. The court ate its way through unbelievable amounts of food — records show over a thousand oxen and eight thousand sheep in a single year, washed down by hundreds of thousands of liters of ale, because even kids drank weak beer — the water wasn't safe. Stand in front of the great roasting fireplace: it burned about a tonne and a half of wood a day, and turning the spit was a real job for a real boy, called a spit boy, who roasted alongside the meat for hours. On special days, costumed cooks still prepare Tudor food here over the actual fire — if it's lit today, you've hit the jackpot. Look for the pastry ovens where cooks built "coffins" — that's really what they called the thick pastry cases they baked meat inside. The pastry was the container, not the treat. And keep an eye out for the wine fountain in the courtyard, a working replica of one Henry really had. At big parties, it flowed with actual wine.

A Kitchen Boy's Long Day

Imagine you are a boy, maybe your age, working in these kitchens in Henry's time. Your day starts before the sun is up. It is dark, it is freezing outside, but not in here, because the great fires never fully go out. Somebody has to keep them fed all night, and quite often that somebody sleeps right here on the kitchen floor, near the warmth, because there is nowhere else to go.

Your job might be turning the spit, the long metal rod that holds the meat over the fire. You crank it, slowly, for hours, and the heat roars into your face until your cheeks are scarlet and your eyebrows feel like they might singe off. Some kitchens had a little screen to protect the spit boy, and some boys just tied a wet cloth over their face and got on with it. Or maybe you work in the scullery, scrubbing an endless mountain of greasy pots and giant cauldrons in cold water until your hands are raw. There were no rubber gloves, no washing-up liquid, just sand and grease and you.

Now think about the drink. Down below the kitchens are the cellars, cool stone rooms stacked with barrels, and this is where the ale was kept, because remember, almost nobody drank plain water, it wasn't safe. Everyone, from the king to the smallest kitchen boy, got a daily allowance of weak beer, and the palace poured through an amount so huge it is hard to picture, hundreds of thousands of pints every year. There was a whole team whose only job was brewing.

And then, twice a day, the moment it was all for. A trumpet sounds. Servants line up and carry the steaming dishes in a great procession up to the Great Hall, holding them high, walking in careful order by rank. Grand men taste the king's food first, in case of poison. It is a show, a performance, as much as a meal, and you, sweaty and sooty at the bottom of it all, helped make it happen. Nobody up in that hall will ever know your name. But without you, the whole glittering machine simply stops.

The Screaming Gallery: Britain's Most Haunted Palace

Hampton Court claims to be the most haunted palace in Britain, and the most famous ghost has a truly sad story. Catherine Howard was Henry the Eighth's fifth wife — a teenager, perhaps only nineteen, when she was accused of betraying the king. The story goes that when guards came for her here in 1541, she broke free, ran down the long gallery toward the chapel where Henry was praying, screaming for mercy, and was dragged back. She was executed at the Tower of London — where you were on Monday. Ever since, that corridor has been called the Haunted Gallery, and visitors have reported screams, sudden cold, and some people feeling faint at the exact same spot. Believe it or not — your choice — but walk it and see how it feels. The palace's other star ghost is "Skeletor": in 2003, security cameras caught fire doors bursting open and a tall figure in old-fashioned robes stepping out to close them. The guards checking the tape had no explanation, and the footage went around the world. Was it a ghost? A costumed guide having fun? The palace, very sensibly, has never said. Ask a warder about it — they love this question.

Catherine Howard: The Real Girl Behind the Scream

The scream in the Haunted Gallery is a ghost story, and nobody knows if it really happened. But behind it is a real girl, and her true story is sadder than any ghost.

Her name was Catherine Howard, and she became Henry's fifth wife when she was very young, probably about seventeen, while Henry was nearly fifty, unwell, and enormous. Picture that. A teenager married off to a grumpy old king because her powerful family thought it would make them richer and more important. She loved dancing and pretty clothes and she was, by every account, full of life.

The trouble was that Catherine had a past before the king, a boyfriend from her teenage years, and after the wedding she foolishly kept spending time with a young man at court. In Tudor times, for a queen, that was not just embarrassing, it was treason, a crime you could die for. When Henry found out, he was crushed, then furious. Catherine was arrested right here at Hampton Court in November of 1541.

And this is where legend takes over from history. The story goes that she broke away from her guards and ran, screaming, down the long gallery toward the chapel, desperate to reach Henry and beg him face to face for her life. The guards caught her and dragged her back, and Henry never spoke to her again. Whether that dash really happened, we truly cannot say. But the fear behind it was absolutely real.

She was taken to the Tower of London, the same fortress you visited on Monday, and executed early in 1542. She was still only a teenager, or barely out of her teens. There is one detail people always remember, though even this may be part legend. They say that the night before she died, she asked for the wooden block to be brought to her room so she could practise laying her head on it, to be calm and dignified at the end. So when you walk that gallery and feel a chill, maybe it isn't a ghost at all. Maybe it's just your heart, aching for a frightened girl who ran out of time.

The White Lady, Skeletor, and Ghost Science

Catherine Howard gets the headlines, but she is not the only ghost people claim to see here. Meet the White Lady. She is said to glide near the riverside and the old rooms where Jane Seymour, Henry's third wife, gave birth to baby Edward and then died, just twelve days later. People who believe in her say she appears dressed all in pale white, carrying a candle, drifting silently and looking terribly sad. Nobody has ever caught her on camera. But a woman who died so young, in a palace this old, does make a very good ghost story.

Then there is the palace's most famous modern mystery, nicknamed Skeletor. In 2003, the palace's own security cameras, the boring kind that watch the fire doors, filmed something strange. The heavy doors flew open by themselves. And then a tall figure in old-fashioned flowing robes stepped calmly out and pulled them shut, as if tidying up. The guards who checked the footage the next morning were baffled. Nobody was supposed to be there. The clip zipped around the whole world. Was it a ghost? A staff member in costume playing a trick? A trick of the camera? The palace has always, very cleverly, refused to say. Ask a warder and watch them smile.

But here is the coolest part, the part where you get to be a scientist. Real researchers came to the Haunted Gallery with proper equipment, thermometers and instruments to measure moving air, and they asked hundreds of visitors to mark on a map exactly where they felt something spooky, a cold spot, a shiver, a sense of being watched. And the answers clustered in the same few places. When the scientists checked those places, they found the ceiling had it right, so to speak, because at those exact spots there were hidden old doorways leaking cold draughts of air. Your body feels the sudden cold, your brain remembers the scary story, and together they conjure a ghost. So here is your mission. Walk the gallery once thinking about nothing, and once thinking about Catherine, and notice how differently it feels. That difference is happening inside you. Congratulations. You just did a real experiment.

The Maze: 350 Years of People Getting Lost

Time for the maze — the oldest surviving hedge maze in Britain, planted around 1700 for King William the Third. It's not huge, about a third of a hectare, but its paths add up to nearly eight hundred meters, and it's a "multicursal" maze, which means it has dead ends and wrong turns designed to trick you. People have been getting lost in these exact hedges for more than three hundred years. Here's a strategy that mathematicians say works in this maze: when you enter, put your left hand on the hedge and never let go — follow every turn while touching the left wall, and you will reach the center. It's slower than being lucky, but it never fails here. Race the grown-ups: kids usually win, and nobody knows why. A famous funny book from 1889, *Three Men in a Boat*, has a whole chapter about a man who leads a crowd of strangers hopelessly around this maze until the old keeper has to climb a ladder and shout directions. Afterwards, burn off whatever energy is left in the Magic Garden playground — dragons, towers, and battlements built for climbing — and if the day is hot, the ice cream by the gates has three centuries of royal tradition behind it. Approximately.

The Oldest Grapevine and the King's Weird Tennis

In a special greenhouse in the gardens grows a plant so old and so enormous it has its own gardener who looks after nothing else. It is the Great Vine, a single grapevine planted in the year 1768, which makes it over two hundred and fifty years old. It was planted when a famous gardener nicknamed Capability Brown was in charge here, grown from a tiny cutting, just a snipped-off twig, brought from another garden. That one twig has become the largest grapevine in the entire world.

Think about that. One plant, but its main stem is now as thick around as a big tree trunk, and its longest branch stretches more than thirty-six metres, longer than a swimming pool, all trained under glass. Every autumn it still grows hundreds of kilos of sweet black grapes, and here is the lovely part, the palace actually sells them to visitors in little baskets in September. Queen Victoria used to have its grapes sent to her for the royal table. So this vine has been feeding kings, queens, and ordinary visitors for a quarter of a thousand years, and it is still going. If it is grape season when you visit, you can eat fruit from a plant that is older than almost every country's flag.

Now, somewhere else in the palace, look for a strange indoor court where a game called real tennis is played. Forget everything you know about normal tennis. This is the wild, medieval grandfather of the sport, played inside a room with sloping roofs along the walls, and you are allowed to bounce the ball off those roofs and even into little windows to score. Henry the Eighth adored it and was brilliant at it when he was young and fit. The court you can peek at today was built for a later king, Charles the First, way back in 1625, and here is the amazing thing, people still play on it. It is the oldest tennis court in Britain that is still in use. So a grapevine older than your great-great-great-grandparents, and a tennis court where a king once sprinted, both still working. Hampton Court is very good at refusing to become the past.

One Palace, Two Worlds

Here's the strangest thing about Hampton Court: it's really two palaces glued together, and you can time-travel between them in a single doorway. The front half is Tudor — twisty red-brick chimneys, Henry the Eighth's Great Hall with its huge wooden roof and tapestries woven with real gold thread. The back half looks like a completely different building: elegant, symmetrical, with rows of tall windows, like Versailles in France. That's because, a hundred and fifty years after Henry, King William the Third and Queen Mary the Second decided the Tudor palace was old-fashioned and embarrassing, and hired Christopher Wren — the St Paul's dome man; he's everywhere on this trip — to knock the whole thing down and build a modern palace. They ran out of money halfway through. Result: Tudor front, baroque back, and the join runs right through the middle. As you cross from one to the other, you're stepping across a hundred and fifty years in one stride. In the Great Hall, look high up into the wooden rafters for tiny carved faces peeking down — they're called eavesdroppers, put there to remind Henry's courtiers that someone was always listening. The walls literally had ears.

The Mole and Wren's Half-Built Palace

The elegant back half of the palace, the part that looks like it belongs in France, exists because of one grumpy royal couple. About a hundred and fifty years after Henry, King William the Third and Queen Mary the Second moved in, took one look at the old Tudor palace, and decided it was hopelessly out of fashion. Everyone rich in Europe wanted a palace like the French king's giant Versailles, so William and Mary hired Christopher Wren, the same genius who built the dome of St Paul's, and told him to knock the whole thing down and start again.

Wren got busy demolishing and rebuilding. And then two things stopped him cold. First, they ran out of money. Second, and worse, Queen Mary suddenly died of smallpox in 1694, when she was only thirty-two. William was so grief-stricken that the great rebuilding lost its heart, and it simply halted, leaving the palace as the mixed-up double building you see today, cosy Tudor at the front, grand new palace at the back, with the join running right down the middle like a seam on a jacket.

Now for the strangest death in the whole story. King William was out riding in the park here in 1702 when his horse suddenly stumbled. What did it trip on? A molehill. A little mound of earth pushed up by a mole doing what moles do. The king was thrown, broke his collarbone, fell ill, and died. His enemies were so delighted that they invented a toast, raising their glasses for years to, and I promise this is true, the little gentleman in black velvet, meaning the mole, whose black fur is soft as velvet. A tiny blind creature underground brought down a king. History does not always feel very grand.

One more twist. In 1986, hundreds of years later, a fire broke out in these very apartments, started by a candle left burning by an elderly resident. Part of Wren's roof was destroyed. But an army of staff formed human chains and carried the priceless paintings out to safety through the smoke, and expert restorers spent six years rebuilding it so beautifully you can barely tell. The palace has survived greedy kings, a mole, and fire. It really does not give up.

Golden Treasure and a Prisoner King

Some of the greatest treasures in this palace are not locked in a case. They are hanging on the walls, and most visitors stroll right past them. Look at the huge cloth pictures covering the walls of the Great Hall. Those are tapestries, and they are not paintings, they are woven, thread by thread by thread, on a loom, a job so slow that one set could take years and cost as much as an entire warship. Henry the Eighth owned hundreds of them and treasured them more than almost anything.

Here is the secret to look for. These tapestries were woven not just with wool and silk but with real gold, thin threads of actual silver and gold twisted into the picture, so that in Henry's day, with candles flickering, the whole wall shimmered and glowed as if it were alive. Five hundred years of dust and smoke have dimmed them to soft browns, but on a bright day, tilt your head and you can still catch a tiny metallic wink in the weave. That is genuine gold, still there, still glinting, after five centuries.

The palace has another jewel hidden in a quiet room, a set of nine gigantic paintings called the Triumphs of Caesar, made in Italy over five hundred years ago by a master artist named Mantegna. They show a Roman general parading home in victory, and they are considered some of the most important old paintings in the whole country. A king bought them because he simply had to have the best.

That king was Charles the First, and his own story here turns dark. He loved beautiful things and filled this palace with treasures. But he ended up on the losing side of a war against his own Parliament, and in 1647 he was brought back to Hampton Court, not as a king in charge but as a prisoner, watched day and night. One November evening he slipped away, escaping through the gardens in the dark and riding for the coast. He didn't get far. He was caught, put on trial, and lost his head. So the same palace held Charles as its proud owner and as its captive. Kings built this place, and this place, more than once, undid them.